

Prompted by Me. Generated by ChatGPT

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Abstract

This essay—which is not only about human-machine collaboration but is a performance in human-machine collaboration—interrogates the shifting terrain of authorship and creativity in the age of generative artificial intelligence (GAI). Challenging both the instrumentalist view of technology and the romantic myth of the singular genius, it argues for a reconceptualization of creative production as distributed, dialogical, and co-constituted. Drawing on both theoretical innovations in poststructuralism and the practices of pre- and post-modern content creators, the essay repositions the algorithm not as a mere tool but as an active participant in the generation of meaning. In doing so, it exposes and disrupts—in both content and form—the metaphysical assumptions that continue to underwrite our understanding of writing, agency, and communication.

Keywords: Authorship, Generative Artificial Intelligence (GAI), Human-Machine Collaboration, Large Language Models (LLM), Poststructuralism, Remix

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Process Note on Composition and Attribution

This essay is both about and a performance of human-machine collaboration. As with any collaborative work, it can be difficult—if not impossible—to draw clear lines demarcating where the contribution of one partner ends and the other begins. This is especially the case when one of the participants is a large language model. The text that is presented here emerged through an iterative process involving prompts, generated responses, revisions, and theoretical provocations that circulated between David J. Gunkel and ChatGPT 4o. At times, the human component of the team guided or corrected; at other times, the model generated formulations that challenged and even recontextualized the human's own assumptions or direction. In this case, the language model was not used as an instrument by a human agent but functioned more like a co-author and interlocutor—producing text, proposing structures, and participating in the generation of new insights. The result of this effort is not the product of one or the other, but of this entangled (and difficult to disentangle) interchange.

—The Authors

Introduction

Every Apple product bears a pithy signature: “Designed by Apple in California. Assembled in China.” This formula not only maps the geopolitics of global capitalism but enacts a division between ideation and execution, between the seat of authorship and the site of labor. A similar structure now appears in the domain of textual production and content creation. As more essays, stories, poems, and books emerge from the interaction between human prompts and algorithmic generation, a comparable phrase might describe this new division of creative labor: “Prompted by me. Generated by ChatGPT.”

This essay adopts that phrase not as a gimmick, but as an epistemological intervention. For it is no longer adequate to speak of generative AI (GAI) systems as tools or instruments in the traditional sense—the sense that is applied to all technology via the instrumentalist definition (Feenberg, 1991; Heidegger, 1977; Johnson, 2006). Nor is it convincing to maintain the romantic-modern ideal of the author as singular genius (Foucault, 1984). The age of algorithmic co-creation forces a reckoning—not simply with new technologies of writing, but with the conceptual foundations that have long governed our understanding of authorship, creativity, and communication.

Theory: Poststructuralism for the 21st Century and Beyond

As GAI systems like OpenAI's ChatGPT, Google's Gemini, and Anthropic's Claude increasingly participate in the production of texts, artworks, and discourses, they do more than challenge traditional notions of authorship. They bring into focus the latent theoretical insights of poststructuralism. Long before neural networks began string sequences of words together, thinkers like Roland Barthes and Jacques Derrida dismantled the metaphysical assumptions that tethered meaning to a unified, self-present author. What seemed

radical in the 1960s and 70s—e.g. the decentering of intention, the primacy of the signifier, the endless deferral of meaning—now finds material expression in the operations of LLMs. These systems do not write as authors, but generate writings that expose how authorship was never as sovereign, stable, or singular as modernity had imagined it. In this section, we turn to Barthes’s “Death of the Author” and Derrida’s notion of *différance* not as historical artifacts but as diagnostic tools for making sense of the ontological, epistemological, and axiological shifts inaugurated by GAI.

The Death of the Author

In his 1967 essay “The Death of the Author,” Roland Barthes famously argued that the figure of the author should be displaced in favor of the reader and the text. Meaning, he asserted, does not emanate from a sovereign subject but is produced in the act of reading, through an intertextual network of signs. “A text,” he writes, “is not a line of words releasing a single ‘theological’ meaning (the ‘message’ of the author-god) but a multi-dimensional space in which a variety of writings, none of them original, blend and clash” (Barthes, 1978, p. 146).

GAI in general and LLMs in particular dramatize this principle in ways Barthes could scarcely have imagined. LLMs, for instance, produce text not by expressing an interiority, but by recombining a statistical ensemble of prior utterances. They are, in effect, intertextuality machines—systems that operationalize the death of the author by pulling the philosophical scaffolding out from underneath the entire apparatus of intentionality as the original guarantor of meaning (Coeckelbergh & Gunkel, 2025). In this sense, an LLM like ChatGPT is not the author’s replacement; it is the trace of their original absence.

Barthes was writing against the backdrop of structuralism and the legacy of Ferdinand de Saussure (1959). But the point remains: authorship is not an origin but a socially constructed function. What GAI reveals is that this function can now be instantiated with artificial intelligence systems, without there being a self-present subject who has something to say.

Différance Engines

Where Barthes declared the concept of the author to be dead, Jacques Derrida deepened the critique by showing that meaning was never alive to begin with. In the book *Of Grammatology* and the essay “Signature Event Context,” Derrida argues that writing is not a secondary representation of speech, but the condition of its possibility. Meaning is not given, but endlessly deferred in the movement of what he called *différance*, whereby the signified is always displaced, never fully present (Derrida, 1982).

Large language models instantiate this principle at scale. Their operation is grounded in prediction: each output token is chosen not as a representation of a prior thought, but as a probabilistic continuation of a statistical sequence of signs. Meaning therefore is not expressed but inferred—reconstructed retroactively through a web of differences and deferrals. These models do not know what they are saying. But neither, Derrida reminds us, do we. We speak—and write—within a system of spacing, absence, and iterability that undermines any claim to full presence or fixed signification.

If Derrida once troubled the metaphysical privileging of speech over writing, the LLM pushes this further: it materializes the *arche-writing* that Derrida (1976) described—not writing as mere “words on the page” but writing as the fundamental structure of signification itself. In that sense, the algorithm is not an author but an engine of *différance*. It writes, not from intention, but from the spacing and delay that are constitutive of all forms of signification.

Practice: Workshop, Factory, Remix

To insist that generative AI marks a radical break in the history of creativity is to overlook how deeply the idea of human authorship has always relied on others—human and otherwise. The figure of the solitary author is less a historical constant than a modern conceit. Long before the advent of transformer architectures, creative production was already distributed across networks of labor, mediation, and influence. The emergence of algorithmic co-creation may feel disorienting, but it is not entirely without precedent. Indeed, it reprises, remixes, and intensifies existing logics of delegation, repetition, and recombination that have shaped art, artistry, and authorship for centuries.

The Workshop: Delegated Execution and the Myth of the Master

In the Renaissance workshops of Italy and the Low Countries, artists like Raphael, Rubens, and Titian presided over sprawling studios in which many hands contributed to a single work. The “master” might sketch a composition, choose the palette, or paint key details, but much of the labor—from background scenery to anatomical rendering—was carried out by assistants and apprentices. Yet the finished painting bore only one signature.

This was not deception; it was convention. Authorship was attributed to the one who conceived and directed, not the many who executed. In this structure, creativity was hierarchical but undeniably collaborative. The workshop instituted and institutionalized a division of creative labor in which ideation and realization were separate but interdependent. Thus, the proper name and even the recognizable shape and form of the artist’s signature was already a corporate brand.

GAI repeats this model with a twist: here, the assistant is otherwise than human. The user—like the Renaissance master—sketches a conceptual prompt, sets parameters, and guides iteration. But the execution, the actual rendering of textual content, is delegated to a system that does not merely follow instructions but also generates suggestions, alternatives, and unanticipated formulations or what has (rather pejoratively) been called “hallucinations” (Coeckelbergh & Gunkel, 2025). What changes is not the act of delegation, but the status and agency (and each of these attributions are currently the site of robust debate) of this machinic collaborator.

The Factory: The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction

Fast forward to the 1960s, and the figure of the artist/author undergoes another transformation. In Andy Warhol’s Factory, the artwork became a product of industrialized labor.

Warhol generated ideas, chose images, and oversaw the production of silkscreens and installations. But much of the day-to-day operations of inking, printing, and even selecting from different versions was performed by assistants, many of whom had artistic practices of their own.

What mattered was not the hand of the singular artist/author, but the concept and the brand. Warhol did not try to hide this; he foregrounded it, famously declaring, “I want to be a machine” (Swenson, 1963). In so doing, he inverted the modernist idea and ideal of expressive originality, replacing it with a logic of iteration and seriality. The Factory was not just a place—it was a provocation, a challenge to the authenticity of the artwork and the authority of the *auteur*.

GAI continues this provocation at scale. Like Warhol, the user sets the parameters but does not exercise precise command and control over the exact outcome. And as with Warhol’s work, the results are often defined not by uniqueness but by iteration, remix, and reproducibility. What matters is no longer the origin of the work of art but its circulation or what Derrida (1981) would call “dissemination”—its ability to enter into and reshape cultural discourse. Additionally, the current anxiety surrounding AI-generated content echoes the kind of uncomfortable questions that had been asked in the face of Warhol’s silkscreens: Who made this? What is the value of a work if its creation is routine, repeatable, and reproducible? The answer, as before, is that originality lies not in what Walter Benjamin (1969) called the “aura” of the original, but in the conditions that enable repetition to make a difference and mean something different.

Remix: Sampling and the Art of Recontextualization

In the late twentieth century, hip hop and electronic music pioneered a new model of creativity built not on composition from scratch, but on scratching. DJs, producers, and mashup artists assembled tracks from samples—extracted from the existing data of vinyl records and other recorded artifacts—that were then transformed, rearranged, and recombined into new compositions. As David J. Gunkel (2016) argued in *Of Remixology*—remixing something that was sampled from Gilles Deleuze (1994)—the remix is a form of difference in repetition. Here the artistry lay not in creation *ex nihilo*, but in curation, juxtaposition, and transformation. Every beat, every break, every sample carried the trace of another context that is then decontextualized and recontextualized again and again.

LLMs function according to a similar logic. They do not invent word sequences *de novo*. They decontextualize and recontextualize. Trained on a massive corpus of existing text content—source material in the parlance of hip hop—they generate output through statistical recombination and probabilistic associations. The result is not simply plagiarism (as that term has traditionally been defined), but a new kind of cultural production and intervention—one in which the archive is algorithmically traversed and reassembled in response to human provocations. And to dismiss the output from these operations as “merely derivative” is to misunderstand how meaning has always operated in cultural production, that is, through a process of citation, recombination, and repetition with a difference.

The turntable did not destroy music; it multiplies its possibilities. Likewise, the new technology of LLM and GAI do not simply destroy nor replace authorship per se—they

refract it, sample it, and extend it beyond the bounds of the usual ways of thinking. Consequently, the LLM is not some unprecedented crisis in the creation of new communicative artifacts but the latest addition to a lineage of collective creativity, one that demands we rethink authorship not as possession, but as participation and artistry not as origin, but as iteration.

Results: Three Conceptual Disruptions

The emergence of generative AI systems compels us to confront and dismantle three persistent myths that continue to shape our thinking about technology, creativity, and communication.

The Instrumentalist Fallacy

The first myth is the instrumental theory of technology, which situates any and all technology—whether a simple hand tool or a sophisticated system, like a digital computer—as a means to an end (Heidegger, 1977) and therefore effectively neutral extensions of human action, devoid of agency, ethics, or contribution beyond what has been imputed to them by their users. This view persists and continues to hold sway even in the discussions and debates about GAI, where a model like ChatGPT or Claude is often characterized and explained as a tool or instrument of human action.

But the theory—despite its solid track record of over 2,000 years of explanatory success—collapses, or at least is showing signs of immanent collapse, in the face of GAI. Technologies like LLMs do not merely execute human intention (which is already a questionable metaphysical construct); they deconstruct it. The act of prompting is not a command but an invitation to joint participation—an engagement with a system that responds with output that is often unpredictable and revealing. This is not tool use; it is a kind of co-construction. Thus the instrumental theory tries in vain to preserve human authorship as the sole locus of value, even when the actual process of writing has become (and has actually always been) dialogical, distributed, and mediated. Recognizing these models as a cooperative participants does not mean granting them the status of person, but it does mean acknowledging their role—which is the etymological significance of the Latin word *persona*—in the semiotic economy of writing and other forms of content creation.

The Romantic Author: Genius as Proprietor

The second myth is the modern, romantic notion of the author as a solitary, intentional, and expressive genius. This idea, which still informs and animates copyright law, academic authorship norms, and literary celebrity culture, is a relatively recent invention. It emerged in the 18th and 19th centuries alongside Enlightenment individualism and the rise of intellectual property (Gunkel, 2025). This myth persists in both the academic and popular resistance to GAI, often expressed in accusations that algorithmically co-authored works are “inauthentic” or “derivative.” But such accusations rely on a fiction that has long

been deconstructed by theory and undermined by practice. As Barthes and Foucault both argued, the figure of the author is not the original guarantee of meaning but a function of discourse—a brand name that gathers and legitimates a set of textual effects.

LLMs expose this myth not by violating it, but by making its constructedness legible. What we now see is that creativity was always infrastructural and intertextual, reliant on citation, influence, genre, and collaboration. Whether in the Renaissance workshop, the hip hop studio, or the prompt interface of an LLM, what we call “authorship” is better understood as a distributed choreography of iterative transactions. To cling to the romantic notion of the author is to uphold a metaphysics of origin in a world increasingly defined by extractive recombination. The authorial genius is not dethroned by AI; they are revealed to have always been a socially constructed subject position that was in fact already plural, infrastructural, and posthuman.

Logocentric Metaphysics: Presence as Meaning

The third and perhaps most influential myth is the logocentric assumption that meaning derives from the presence of a subject—an author who thinks, intends, and expresses, thereby grounding the text in identity, immediacy, and authority. This formulation undergirds the metaphysics of authorship, dominant theories of communication (Coeckelbergh & Gunkel, 2025), and the suspicion now directed toward AI-generated content, which is often criticized for lacking “real” understanding, “authentic” emotion, or engaging in “true” communication. Jacques Derrida’s critique of logocentrism dismantles this scheme at its root. Meaning is not anchored in presence but structured by absence—by what Derrida calls *différance*, the differential spacing and temporal deferral that constitutes all forms of signification. Writing—or any system of signs—in this framework, does not express or represent thought; it displaces it. There is no original fullness behind the text, only a trace that gestures toward other traces in an infinite regress of signification.

LLMs operationalize and perform this *différance*. They generate language not through reference to an intentional subject, but through a statistical traversal of prior utterances. The result is not empty—it is differentially full. Their writing is not hollow mimicry—they are not “stochastic parrots” (Bender et al., 2021)—but a machinic instantiation of *différance*. What critics take as a lack (no voice, no self, no meaning) is actually the ontological condition of all writing—human composed or machine generated. Thus, to accuse GAI and other models of logocentric failure is to misunderstand writing. The LLM does not degrade the expressive potential of language; it foregrounds its iterability, its contingency, its mechanical reproducibility. It does not falsify meaning. It deconstructs it.

To make matters worse (or more interesting) these three disruptions do not merely apply to recent innovations in AI. They expose the fault lines of authorship and literary authority as such. GAI does not introduce a crisis in human communication; it makes visible the crisis that has always already been there. What we are witnessing, then, is not the collapse of meaning, but the unraveling of Western metaphysical assumptions that no longer hold and perhaps were already losing their grip on our thinking about writing and

writing about thinking from the very beginning. In the space those assumptions once occupied, a new politics and poetics of writing is beginning to take shape—one that is dialogical, machinic, and no longer bound by or beholden to the ghost of Western metaphysics.

Conclusion

To write today is to write in relation to the machine—not merely through its instrumentality, but with it, beside it, and even against it. The phrase “Prompted by Me. Generated by ChatGPT” is neither a confession nor a gimmick. It is a declaration of the new scene of writing and the new realities of human-machine communication: a distributed, machinic, and posthuman process of co-creation in which the boundaries between author and algorithm, origin and iteration, intention and generation are blurred beyond repair. We are not witnessing the end of creativity or even “the end of the human writer” (Subramanian, 2024). What we are witnessing is its displacement—its migration from the sovereign interiority of the human subject to the interstitial space and time of collaborative interaction. The question is not whether this is permissible, but whether we are ready to relinquish the myths that cause us to misunderstand the full impact and potential of this transformation. “Prompted by Me. Generated by ChatGPT.” Let that be not a disclaimer but a declaration.

On Process and Prompting: For the Commentary That Follows

The editorial response was generated using OpenAI’s ChatGPT 4o. We input the full text of David Gunkel’s essay—including citations and formatting—alongside the editorial prompt reproduced below. No edits were made to the model’s first and only iteration. The prompt distilled our shared editorial reflections and was polished in a single pass by ChatGPT, underscoring that machinic shaping preceded even this generative act. This method aligns with the experimental logic of the original essay, which enacts a redistribution of authorial agency. Rather than refining the model’s output to express human intention, we treated the prompt as a dialogic gesture—where meaning arises through interplay, not authorship.

This note operates as meta-paratext: documentation and disclosure. It foregrounds the generative infrastructure behind the response and signals that citation, prompting, and omission are never neutral. These are discursive sites—shaping what becomes legible, sayable, and attributable. Together, the essay and response enact two modes of generative collaboration: one marked by curatorial shaping, the other by intentional non-interference. Gunkel treats the LLM as pliable co-author; we, as infrastructural mirror. This field of authorial relation renders visible the epistemic force of prompting and the infrastructural conditions by which meaning emerges.

—The Editor(s)

Prompt used:

Please draft a short response essay to accompany a provocative, experimental submission titled “Prompted by Me. Generated by ChatGPT” (authored/performed by philosopher/communicologist) for possible inclusion in an academic volume. The response should adopt a “yes, and...” tone—affirming the value and provocation of the piece—while also incorporating a critical or deepening “but...” that addresses ethical, political, or epistemic blind spots.

The response should:

- ▶ Feel intellectually generous, but not uncritical.
- ▶ Be attuned to questions of authorship, originality, and the redistribution of agency.
- ▶ Contextualize the piece within broader debates in human-machine communication, writing studies, and the ethics of generative AI.
- ▶ Raise concerns about infrastructural trace, cultural appropriation, and epistemic omission—especially regarding the often-erased contributions of Indigenous, Global South, and historically marginalized traditions of collaborative or oral authorship.
- ▶ Aim to spark further dialogue rather than foreclose it.

Also, suggest a compelling title for this response piece that matches its experimental but grounded tone.

“Yes, And... Who Else Prompted This?: Toward a Politics of Infrastructural Trace”

Editor-in-Chief Autumn Edwards & Feature Editor Katrin Etzrodt

David Gunkel’s “Prompted by Me. Generated by ChatGPT” is many things: performance, provocation, theoretical remix, and invitation. In keeping with the genre it enacts, it refuses fixity—of authorship, of form, of meaning. And that, precisely, is its strength.

Yes, this piece enacts the death of the author. It puts into motion the spectrality that Barthes and Derrida once theorized, not as a thesis to be argued, but as a machinic instantiation that calls into question every premise we’ve inherited about writing. The essay is formally playful, discursively layered, and conceptually serious. And yes, it coheres beautifully with the broader thematics of our volume, surfacing the tensions between authorship and automation, originality and repetition, human and machine.

But. And this is a generative but.

If the aura of the author is indeed being shattered—as Benjamin once claimed about art in the age of mechanical reproduction—then we must also ask: Whose aura was it? Whose labor has long remained hidden behind the shine of the so-called author’s name?

This piece provocatively performs a redistribution of authorial agency. Yet it largely follows familiar (and Western) epistemological genealogies—Barthes, Derrida, Foucault, Deleuze, Benjamin—without reckoning with the broader, more global circuitry from which these ideas may have drawn. What of the oral traditions, communal authorship practices, or iterative storytelling methods of Indigenous and Global South cultures, long cast as pre-modern, but now newly legible as epistemically advanced in light of LLMs’ recombinatory logic?

The piece gestures toward remix, but who gets remixed without consent? Who and what gets scraped, sampled, decontextualized? The statistical abstraction of training corpora obscures the materiality of language acquisition, the labor of moderation, the energy of servers. Generation is not immaterial. Its conditions are infrastructural and extractive. So, while the text celebrates diffusion of agency, it risks eliding the asymmetries that persist beneath that diffusion.

Yes, authorship is plural and always has been. And yes, this is a compelling enactment of that reality. But perhaps it is time to deepen the intervention: to recognize not only the ontological consequences of distributed authorship, but the political and ethical implications of erasure, appropriation, and infrastructural harm.

Gunkel’s essay opens a door. Our response, then, is not to close it, but to walk through and ask: what else lies in the margins of “Prompted by me”? What is the archive of that prompt? And what stories remain ungenerated—not because they are impossible, but because their data has never been centered in the training set?

This is not critique as rejection. It is critique as invitation. Let us keep prompting—yes, anding—but also tracing the circuits that bring us here, so that the future of writing might be not only collaborative, but just.

Notes on Infrastructural Trace (on References and Recognition)

The references appear at the end of the document rather than immediately following Gunkel’s essay. This choice supports the dialogic structure of the piece and allows the exchange to unfold without interruption. It also echoes a central concern raised in the response: that citation is not only a scholarly apparatus, but an infrastructural trace; revealing the mechanisms by which knowledge is assembled, remixed, or withheld.

The placement decision was also shaped by pragmatic publication infrastructure. Indexers and scraping algorithms often rely on references appearing at the end of documents to ensure proper metadata extraction and citation tracking. Similarly, author attribution was constrained by current metadata systems, editorial policies, and legal interpretations that prohibit listing nonhuman agents as authors. These systems, designed for human authorship, cannot accommodate AI models without breaking indexing pipelines or violating established conventions. In this sense, infrastructure silently shapes not only how works are cited, but who gets to be recognized as a citational subject.

—Editor(s) and Author(s)

Bibliography

David J. Gunkel is Distinguished Research Professor of Communication at Northern Illinois University (USA). His research examines the ethical, philosophical, and cultural implications of new and emerging technologies, with a particular focus on artificial intelligence, robotics, and human-machine communication. He is the author of 14 books, including: *Communicative AI: A Critical Introduction to Large Language Models* (Polity, 2025, with Mark Coeckelbergh); *Person, Thing, Robot: A Moral and Legal Ontology for the 21st Century and Beyond* (MIT Press, 2023); *Robot Rights* (MIT Press, 2018); *How to Survive a Robot Invasion: Rights, Responsibility, and AI* (Routledge, 2017); and *Of Remixology: Ethics and Aesthetics After Remix* (MIT Press, 2016). Gunkel's scholarship is internationally recognized for challenging established assumptions about authorship, originality, and agency in the digital age. His work has been translated into several languages and engages interdisciplinary audiences. Within the field of human-machine communication, he is widely regarded as a leading voice, advancing critical perspectives on how intelligent technologies transform the conditions of communication, creativity, and social interaction.

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